



▲ EMPEROR GAOZU

Liu Bang began life as a peasant and then became a bandit and rebel chieftain. Out of the chaos that followed the collapse of the ruling Qin empire, he emerged as the most powerful leader. In 202 BCE, he declared himself founder of the new Han Dynasty, and took the title Emperor Gaozu.

EMPEROR WU

Emperor Wu (reigned 141–87 BCE) was the seventh ruler of the Han Dynasty. Under his long rule, China became a powerful empire. Wu was inspired by the teachings of the philosopher Confucius, which emphasize respecting others and honoring tradition. He made

Confucianism the official school of thought for his kingdom.



▼ TOMBS AND TREASURES

The Han believed in the afterlife, and were buried with belongings they felt their souls would need after death. The very wealthy, such as members of the royal family, were laid to rest in suits made out of expensive jade.

Han China

After the death of the first emperor, Qin Shi Huangdi, in 210 BCE, civil war broke out across China. In 202 BCE, the Han Dynasty took power and reunified the kingdom. Han emperors organized the empire well. Under their rule, China went through an age of economic prosperity, and many new inventions improved daily life.

Han rule over China falls into two distinct periods—the Western Han period up to c. 9 CE, when the capital was at Chang'an, and the Eastern Han period from c. 25 CE until 220 CE, when Luoyang became the capital. The years in between saw the brief rule of the Xin Dynasty.

The Han set up an efficient civil service to manage their vast empire, and established a permanent army paid for by taxes, and not by the training of peasants. However, Eastern Han rule was not very stable, and the

transfer of power from one leader to the next was seldom trouble-free. There were often power struggles between members of the imperial family, officials, and warlords, while peasant uprisings weakened the government's grip on power. As the ruling elite became increasingly cut off from ordinary people, those excluded from power began to arm themselves. After a major rebellion in 184 CE, the Han Empire finally collapsed in 220 CE, bringing in an era of rival warlords.



◀ EXPANDING THE EMPIRE

By 87 CE, the Han Empire covered much of eastern modern China, along with northern Vietnam and Korea. During the Eastern Han period, the emperors made alliances with tribes in the north and the west, extending the empire as far as Central Asia.



Jade was believed to protect the body from decay.